

Information snowballing: information practices in the context of sustainable food practices

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Abstract

Purpose – This research aims to introduce the concept of information snowballing, which shows the process of how individuals with a specific interest in food sustainability acquire information about and remain abreast of sustainability-related information in everyday life and food practices.

Design/methodology/approach – This study employed constructivist grounded theory to investigate the information acquisition practices of consumers of sustainable food around topics related to sustainability. The author collected data through pre-screening phone calls, photo diaries and in-depth semi-structured interviews by using theoretical sampling with nine sustainable food consumers; analyzed data through constant comparison and memoing; and validated findings via methodological jotting, data triangulation and peer-debriefing throughout the process.

Findings – The findings identify three stages of information snowballing: (a) learning by lifelong exposure and serendipitous information encountering; (b) constructing information landscapes; and (c) snowballing or gradually accumulating information.

Practical implications – This concept advocates for spreading sustainability-related information and awareness outside the context of formal education.

Originality/value – This study originates the concept of “information snowballing,” which evolves from the idea of snowball sampling, a common strategy for participant recruitment. Both of these terms lean on the idea that a snowball rolling downhill picks up more and more momentum and more and more snow as it travels; recruitment and information gathering show the same process of accretion through building momentum. Information snowballing highlights the individual’s agency in seeking relevant information sources, expressing one’s interests, constructing information landscapes—all activities that precede the serendipitous encountering and snowballing of information based on a particular interest. It also connects everyday information practices to information landscapes within the context of everyday food practices.

Keywords Information practice, Everyday information behavior, Information encountering,

Information landscape, Sustainability, Food

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

This paper introduces the concept of information snowballing by tracing how people interested in sustainable food both acquire information about and remain abreast of sustainability-related information, with special attention to how this happens in the context of their everyday lives. In Library and Information Science (LIS), the study of information practices often explores not only active information seeking but also passive information encountering (Liu *et al.*, 2021). Yet, prior research in information encountering (IE) has focused mostly on serendipitous information discovery of useful and interesting information, but little is known of how spontaneous encounters with information are affected by users’ particular interests, hobbies or altruism around certain topics. In addition, most investigations of IE have focused on how professionals or academics encounter information in online environments; little attention has been paid to how laypeople encounter information in everyday life contexts.

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This is especially true of the contexts around food practices, an information-rich area. Studying food-related information behavior contributes to the theoretical development in LIS, as well as having practical implications for marketing and design about food (Ocepek, 2016, p. 30). However, prior research into food-related information behavior and practice has been limited to contexts such as shopping, cooking and eating. It has not attended to other food practice-related contexts that are highly relevant for individuals with an interest in sustainable food, such as gardening, composting and recycling. This paper seeks to address this gap, presenting results from a constructivist grounded theory study investigating how sustainable food consumers acquire and encounter information about sustainable food and living practices in the context of their everyday lives and food. This paper proposes a concept of information snowballing that emerged from the data collected in this study, offering specific examples of the information sources and activities people used during this process. This concept extends our understanding of everyday information practices, information landscapes and IE in the context of interests, hobbies and altruism. The paper concludes with practical implications and future research directions.

2. Literature review

2.1 Sustainability

Over the past decade, scholars in library and information science (LIS) have shown a growing interest in sustainability, especially after the United Nations established 17 sustainable development goals (SDGs) and after the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic. Although sustainability is not a new concept in LIS, its scope is often limited to libraries, such as greening library buildings, preserving cultural heritage in archives and offering digital services (Kamińska *et al.*, 2021). Thus, research about other SDGs outside of libraries remains understudied in LIS, such as zero hunger, sustainable consumption and production and climate actions. This study aims to extend research on sustainable consumption and production in everyday life.

2.2 Information encountering

Active information seeking and searching have been widely studied in LIS, but passive information acquisition has only begun to draw scholarly attention in recent decades. Serendipity, one primary phenomenon studied in passive information acquisition, originated outside of LIS and was first introduced to LIS by Bernier in 1960 (McBirnie, 2008; Merton and Barber, 2011). It refers to the “fortuitous discovery” of new information while searching to facilitate research progress (Bernier, 1960). Early research about serendipity therefore originally centered around the information behavior of scholars or professionals, examining how they generate new ideas or knowledge through serendipitous information encounters: examples included inter-disciplinary researchers, who frequently encounter serendipitous information (Foster and Ford, 2003). Until recently, LIS scholars have conceptualized this phenomenon under a single unified concept of IE (Erdelez and Makri, 2020).

IE describes the experience of “finding interesting, useful or potentially useful information” in three scenarios: “when looking for some other information, not looking for any information in particular, or not looking for information at all” (Erdelez and Makri, 2020, p. 5). These three scenarios are associated with three pre-encounter tasks: (1) active seeking of information (e.g. searching); (2) passive information acquisition or seeking without a goal, such as browsing social media; and (3) everyday life tasks (e.g. food shopping, watching videos) (Erdelez and Makri, 2020). To date, little empirical research has focused on IE in the course of everyday life tasks: Yadamsuren and Erdelez (2010) investigated IE while reading online news, and Makri and Blandford (2012, p. 10) found that architecture design students found inspiration about sustainable architecture design after watching comedy TV shows. This study aims to address this gap, further extending empirical research into how laypeople encounter information in the everyday, non-informational practices of food.

2.3 Information landscape

When knowledge is still developing, especially knowledge of sustainability and sustainable food practices, constructing a new way of knowing is vital to making life decisions. To accomplish this goal, people often construct information landscapes through interactions with modalities, people, objects, communities, etc. (Lloyd and Olsson, 2019). For instance, when refugees first arrive in a host country, their lack of knowledge about information sources, information infrastructures and healthcare systems in the host country may prevent them from making health-related decisions (Lloyd, 2006). As a result, information landscape emerged as a vital concept that explains how individuals develop ways of knowing and doing in a relatively new information environment (Lloyd, 2014, 2015). This concept refers to a socially constructed space where people have mutually agreed-upon knowledge, information, information sources and ways of knowing. Additionally, the scholar emphasizes the relationship between the information landscape and professional practices: “People construct their information landscape when they engage or connect to a particular practice, for example, firefighting” (Savolainen, 2021, p. 659). Therefore, it is worth further exploring how people interact with other people, objects, communities or places to make sustainable food choices when knowledge of sustainability has not yet been fully established.

2.4 Food and information

Food-related practices have been fruitful research areas in LIS (Hartel, 2003, 2006, 2010; Ocepek, 2018). Early studies investigating the information behaviors of gourmet cooking hobbyists and grocery shoppers have deepened our understanding of information activities and sources. Hartel (2003, 2010) identified some major information activities for cooking hobbyists, including managing cookbooks, magazines or recipes from previous generations, creating recipes or action plans, and using and reusing informational documents such as instructions for particularly complicated recipes or meal plans. More recently, Ocepek has reconceptualized the notion of *everyday* and at the same time bridged the gap between work and nonwork contexts by emphasizing the mundane activities of everyday life, framing people as everyday experts in their own daily activities and lived experiences. This approach expands the research focus on formal and documented information gathering activities to include sensory, material and lived experience. For example, during food shopping, everyday grocery shoppers supplement their more formal information seeking, encountering, sharing and browsing behaviors with bodily and sensory information via sight, taste, touch and smell. This critical approach has been further developed by Polkinghorne, who incorporated bodily and material practices with cognitive information-gathering behaviors, creating a holistic approach (Polkinghorne, 2021; Polkinghorne and Given, 2021). In this holistic perspective, food-related information practices are “ongoing, generative, [and] open-ended,” taking place not only in formal searches but through IE and sharing behaviors within families or close friends. Polkinghorne has shown that both individual sensory ways of knowing and moral concerns affect people’s everyday food and information practices. This study seeks to follow up on Polkinghorne’s identification of moral concerns as a factor that affects information practices, attending to the information practices of people driven by altruism who have strong environmental and social consciousness—an area of research that is vastly understudied in LIS. Therefore, this study seeks to answer the following research question, which guided the data collection and analysis:

RQ1. How do people become and remain informed of sustainable food practices?

3. Methodology and methods

This section outlines and explains this study’s constructivist grounded theory methodology, its methods of participant recruitment, its participant demographic information, and the strategies of data collection and data analysis used.



The study used a qualitative constructivist grounded theory (CGT) approach to investigate the information behaviors of sustainable food consumers around their everyday food practices, including food production, acquisition, shopping and waste disposal. CGT investigates what participants say and do, situating these activities in time, space, action and interaction (Charmaz, 2014). In CGT, realities or data are relative and co-constructed through interaction and interpretation between researchers and participants. CGT, like practice theory, views knowledge as being co-constructed between humans and society or humans and objects within a cultural, historical and institutional context; this provides a dynamic view of knowledge as being embedded in the interaction between individuals and society. In both CGT and practice theory, knowledge becomes a way of “knowing how or wanting to know” how to do or use something (Reckwitz, 2002), instead of a “thing” that exists somewhere that can be extracted. In this study, CGT guides both systematic data collection and data analysis through constant comparison and reflection, including writing methodology journals and memoing. This study was approved by the Institutional Review Board (IRB) at Rutgers University (ID number: Pro2021002238).

3.1 Participants

In total, there were nine participants, recruited from multiple Facebook special interest groups (SIG) about sustainability, gardening, zero-waste and volunteering via snowball sampling. Participants self-identified as making food choices based on environmental and social consciousness. Pseudonyms were either chosen by participants or randomly assigned by the researcher. Table 1 shows the demographic characteristics of all participants.

3.2 Data collection

Data was collected through pre-screening phone calls, photo diaries and semi-structured interviews with nine participants. First, the pre-screening phone calls (lasting 5–15 min) collected demographic information, ensured participants’ eligibility and assigned pseudonyms. Notes were taken in those phone calls, but they were not recorded for analysis. During these calls, participants were asked to take 5–10 photos of food acquisition practices that were influenced by their environmental and social concerns (e.g. purchased food items, home gardens), and to take photos of any information that influenced their choices about what food to buy or consume (e.g. posters in store, food packaging). Participants emailed me these photos before the scheduled interview, and we discussed them during the semi-structured interviews. Recruitment, which was guided by theoretical sampling to explore

Table 1. Sociodemographic characteristics of participants

Pseudonym	Gender	Highest educational level	Ethnicity	Political affiliation
Linda	Female	Postgraduate	Caucasian	Demo
Sharon	Female	Post-baccalaureate	Caucasian	Demo
Ann	Female	Postgraduate	Caucasian	Demo
Alma	Female	Postgraduate	Caucasian	Demo
Louise	Female	Undergraduate	Caucasian	Not a US citizen yet, but will vote for Demo
Velva	Female	Post-baccalaureate	Caucasian	Demo
April	Female	Graduate	Filipino/Asian	Liberal and Demo
Emily	Female	Undergraduate	Caucasian	Demo
Samantha	Female	Graduate	Caucasian	None

Note(s): Post-baccalaureate degrees refer to taking graduate-level courses after finishing undergraduate degrees
Source(s): Authors’ own work

underdeveloped concepts (Corbin and Strauss, 2015), lasted from January to July 2022. Recruitment stopped when saturation was reached—when there was enough data to have explanatory power and meet the purposes of the research (Corbin and Strauss, 2015; Low, 2019, p. 136). In this study, saturation was reached when data analysis, re-analysis and new data collection no longer added new properties to explain the concept of information snowballing or to answer the research question: How do people become and remain abreast of sustainable food practices? Meanwhile, similar patterns of how people get informed about sustainable food were observed among different participants. Yet, we do acknowledge that there can always be new insights to be made with new data (Low, 2019, p. 135). As such, other concepts not fully explored in this research (e.g. information avoidance) are acknowledged as limitations.

The semi-structured interviews, conducted over Zoom, lasted 45–90 min and were audio recorded, then transcribed verbatim. The interviews investigated participants' perceptions about sustainability, food consumption and food information practices. All interviews started with standardized questions that all participants answered; new questions were asked during or at the end of the interviews when relevant topics emerged (Corbin and Strauss, 2015, p. 39). In CGT, initial interviews may begin with sensitizing concepts, researchers' interests or disciplinary perspectives. Everyday information practice was the sensitizing theory in our research (e.g. information needs, seeking, sources), in part because little LIS research has been done into the information practices of ethical consumers. Yet the initial questions that grew out of these sensitizing concepts were also somewhat flexible. For instance, early participants were asked to recall a time when it was difficult for them to find information they sought. However, most of these early participants had relatively positive experiences with information access, so later participants were also asked what information was missing when they made food choices and how they evaluated the real impact of their sustainable food practices (A paper on this concept of *assessing the real impact* has already been published elsewhere; Du, 2022).

The photo-elicitation techniques mentioned above were used as a communication tool to expand questions (Clark-Ibáñez, 2004) or elicit more information and memories (Harper, 2002) about participants' food and information practices. Additional relevant data—often follow-ups on information mentioned by participants during the interviews, such as a photo of a seed collection box, names of documentaries, websites of non-governmental organizations (NGOs), or information about food providers—were collected from participants or online after the interviews ended. In total, 531 min of interviews and 67 photos were collected for data analysis.

3.3 Data analysis

Data were coded in NVivo using two coding processes: *initial coding* and *focused coding* (Charmaz, 2014). Initial coding includes coding for gerunds, line-by-line coding, asking questions and using sensitizing concepts from the human information behavior and practices research described in the literature review section of this article (e.g. information sources, information activities). Focused coding generates conceptual categories from initial codes by making constant comparisons between codes, data, people, situations, contexts or categories (Thornberg and Charmaz, 2014). NVivo's "Matrix Coding Query" feature under the "Explore" tab was also used to explore the relationships between different concepts.

The results of these constant comparisons and asking questions guided the *theoretical sampling*, which refers to sampling "concepts and not people, *per se*" (Corbin and Strauss, 2015). Unlike selective sampling, which is based on population and settings before data collection, theoretical sampling emerges out of the ongoing data collection and analysis process of grounded theory (Draucker *et al.*, 2007). Analysis of previously collected data guides the researcher to recruit new participants from new settings and ask new questions in order to maximize the similarities and differences in properties or dimensions of theoretical

concepts. In this study, for instance, the *real impact assessment* concept (Du, 2022) emerged from the first interview, and the *information snowballing* concept emerged from analysis of the third interview.

A few strategies have been used to increase the trustworthiness of the CGT methodology used in this study. First, data were triangulated through interviews, photo diaries and secondary sources (e.g. news, names of documentaries, websites and organizations) mentioned by participants during interviews. Second, researcher reflexivity was recorded throughout data collection and analysis using strategies such as jotting and memoing (Morse *et al.*, 2021): jotting is taking methodological notes about procedural aspects of the research, and memoing is a process of data analysis (Corbin and Strauss, 2015). Finally, peer-debriefing was undertaken at weekly to monthly intervals throughout the study to strengthen trustworthiness.

4. Findings

In this section, the participants' characteristics are summarized; this is followed by a discussion of perceptions and definitions of sustainability. The section concludes with a discussion of how participants encountered information about sustainability and sustainable food practices.

4.1 Characteristics of participants

Participants in this study are all self-identified as women who have chosen to engage in certain food practices based on their environmental and social concerns. Most of the participants are self-identified Democrats; one identified herself as liberal and one did not claim a political affiliation, but they all vote frequently. Eight participants were Caucasian, and one was Asian/Filipino. All have university degrees or have engaged in postgraduate study. This demographic information aligns with the demographics of *typical* ethical consumers, who are most often female (Long and Murray, 2013), politically active and well-educated (Schoolman, 2020). Although all participants said they engaged with sustainable food practices very often, the duration and types of sustainable food practices vary, ranging from 2 years to more than 40 years.

4.2 Defining sustainability

Sustainability has been defined as environmental, social and economic sustainability—the “triple bottom lines”—a concept that originated from the corporate sustainability field (Elkington, 1998; Žak, 2015). But participants in this study focused primarily on the first two bottom lines, mostly ignoring the economic dimension. Participants defined sustainability in food production first in terms of contributing to the health of all living beings and of the environment as whole. For instance, Ann's definition of sustainability meant no hormone injection in animals for slaughter, and Velva's meant no pesticides in farming. In Louise's view, animals should be ethically raised and fed by natural resources: “the animals are more humanely raised, and they are being fed grass, which is what they eat, rather than being fattened up on grains which is not, would not be their natural food source.”

Second, they defined sustainability in terms of the regeneration and continuation of existing resources for the current and future generations—for instance, not overfishing in the ocean (Velva), or ensuring long-term soil health (Samantha). According to Samantha, “So sustainability is basically when you can keep something and keep it moving over and over and over again in some way, shape or form. So if we're talking about soil sustainability, you know how can we treat the soil so it's going to give us crops season after season, year after year.”

A final aspect of sustainability that participants emphasized was acknowledging the current climate issues and participating in civic engagement to relieve the environmental burdens on our planet. Alma emphasized that the goal of her everyday practices was “not adding to the

problem of the environmental issues that we are facing.” Emily also highlighted the importance of reducing overconsumption and waste production: “because we have so much waste and we’re such massive consumers in the US and all over the world, to just reducing the amount we’re using and throwing away. And just taking conscious steps to help reduce our carbon footprint.” In summary, participants defined sustainability and sustainable food practices as behaviors that contribute to the health of the environment and all living beings—as an ethically-driven set of behaviors, focusing on regeneration and continuation, that engages in responsive civic and political action to spread its principles.

4.3 Information practices

Before engaging in any type of sustainable food practices, participants first sought to become informed about the topic of sustainable food, for acquiring knowledge or information is a vital step in any hobby (Stebbins, 1994). But the field of sustainability is still very new, and knowledge is still developing. Participants learned different aspects of sustainability over time. Most participants already understood the benefits of buying local and organic food, gardening and supporting community-supported agriculture (CSA), but many were still learning about the problems of plastic packaging, animal cruelty in factory farming, and energy and water footprint in wheat production. Acquiring information and knowledge of sustainability and sustainable food practices can be a continuous and embodied procedure over a long period of time.

The concept of *information snowballing* initially emerged from an *in vivo* code, when one participant, Ann, described acquiring information about the problems with plastic packaging as “snowballed.” Ongoing and iterative data analysis showed that many other participants also experienced information snowballing. For these participants, the gradual acquisition of information to become and remain informed on certain topics went through three stages: (1) learning by lifelong exposure and information encountering (IE), (2) constructing an information landscape and (3) snowballing information.

4.3.1 Learning by lifelong exposure and (IE). According to participants, their information acquisition did not always begin with a clear interest in or awareness of a knowledge gap around sustainability. Some participants encountered information about sustainability as they engaged in leisure reading, video-watching, work or food shopping; others had been exposed to sustainability-related topics since childhood, participating in family gardening and composting since childhood and learning to grow their own produce and compost food waste. Louise recalled learning about growing food, reusing resources and composting food wastes from information or knowledge passed down by the previous generations. Her family had victory gardens or war gardens to reduce the burden of food supply during the Second World War, and since wartime, her family has kept up the tradition of self-producing food sources and composting food wastes in their backyard:

so my mother used to compost, and my grandfather used to compost. . . . during the Second World War, and the government in Germany and the government in England encouraged civilians to grow their own vegetables . . . so is not to take away from the resources from the army . . . so there was much more of a culture of reusing or being resourceful or taking responsibility for one’s own waste in woman’s back yard.

For Louise, knowledge of composting has become a family heritage that is being passed on to the new generation as Louise educates her kids on how to compost food wastes and raise chickens in the backyard during the pandemic lockdown. To encourage her children to be more active and educate them about reducing carbon consumption and emissions by producing own food, Louise rented a coop with two chickens for her backyard (see Plate 1), “teaching them that, you know that, having this food available in your own backyard means that there’s less shipping that you know where it’s come from that it’s fresh.”

Similarly, Samantha had been exposed to a backyard garden as a child and developed an early interest in learning how food is grown. After she gave birth to her son, she started to grow



Source(s): Authors' have been given permission by the participant to use these photos

Plate 1. Rented coop with two chickens in backyard to educate children

her own food in the backyard, and she described her child's joyful experience of learning to harvest:

I said, 'Oh, you know, I think some peas are ready to harvest. We can go get peas, or you can get something from the fridge like, what do you want.' And he's like 'peas,' so we went out, and he saw all these pieces hanging, and just, he screamed with joy. Samantha

In addition to learning from family backyard gardens, participants learned about gardening and composting in local community or nonprofit organizations. Alma, a gardener since childhood, described her access to a local botanical garden where she took classes from a nonprofit organization and learned about gardening and composting in her neighborhood community garden:

I grew up in an urban community, but I was very fortunate to have ready access to the [City Name] botanic garden, and they have wonderful courses, and I had a vegetable garden there, and composting was a really, you know, important part of the cycle of what we did. So I knew about composting, and so I started, so [I was] always composting. Alma

In addition to these types of informal learning, participants also gained knowledge from formal education at school. The knowledge acquired from school, however, did not always create behavioral change in participants. On the one hand, it did inform participants' everyday food practices; for example, Sharon has an educational background in nutrition science and served as a dietitian, where she learned the environmental benefits of buying local and organic food. However, for many participants, formal education added to their knowledge but did not change their everyday behaviors. For example, Linda noted that although her educational background provided knowledge about environmental sustainability, she did not start sustainable food practices until recent years. Linda described learning about healthy organic food by reading magazines at a local grocery store when she worked part-time as a teen:

Well, I think I'm a unique case because when I was a teenager, I worked in a health food shop and, you know, similar to Whole Foods, but on a much smaller scale. And from a young age, I always read [magazines] about health, then organic foods and the benefits of it. Linda

Linda also described her insider knowledge of how to tell if the produce is organic grown by reading food sticker number: "I had experience in the grocery store with it, like, I know that if there's it's a five-digit number on the produce it's organic. If it's a four digit, it's not [organic]. So that's a little tricky".

Other participants were not exposed to sustainability practices or information through formal learning but serendipitously encountered it as they engaged in everyday activities such as reading books, watching videos for leisure and entertainment or shopping in grocery stores. Velda described encountering a book about sustainable food production that started her journey toward food sustainability:

About 2006 I just read that book *Harvest for Hope*, and it started raising my consciousness about food sourcing and what I'm eating and what it does [to the] environment and it just started me on that whole journey about, you know, pesticides in our environment and . . . Velva

Similarly, one participant described her initial exposure to healthy and sustainable food practices as coming through beauty and lifestyle videos on YouTube about fashion and makeup that she watched when she was in high school. She learned about healthy and vegan diets from those videos and from other online content creators. This IE led her to seek more videos and information about vegan diets:

. . . this was like high school, and I was watching a lot of videos of like . . . the beauty gurus like they're kind of like young woman who like did a lot of like fashion and beauty like makeup videos and that kind of levitated to lifestyle videos and like blog style videos and I think that's one people who were vegan or just you know we're sharing their lives promoted that and it got me to look at more vegan videos. Emily

April, who has been on vegetarian diet for health reasons since she was 15 years old, described encountering information in grocery stores, documentaries and museums:

In a variety of contexts some sometimes even just reading the back of a bottle of some you know, a shampoo or something that I, that I have it says it doesn't use palm oil or some food. That actually provides information about that I think it's actually really interesting, good marketing, on behalf of these companies, but also, you know watching documentaries or going to a museum. April

As these stories show, participants initially learned about sustainability and sustainable food practices in several ways: by passive exposure in various places (e.g. backyards, local botanical garden); through formal education programs and classes; and by encountering information during everyday practices and leisure projects (e.g. reading, watching, grocery shopping).

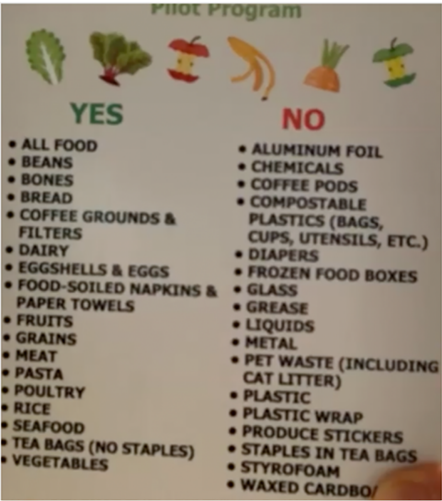
4.3.2 Constructing an information landscape. Once participants formed an interest or hobby or began to practice altruism around sustainability practices, they started to construct an information landscape through different activities, including volunteering, composting, gardening, buying local produce, making their own meals. As they constructed these information landscapes, they learned not just sustainable food practices but also new ways of knowing about sustainability and sustainable food practices, including learning about a variety of new information sources and activities that would expand their understanding.

4.3.2.1 Volunteering in communities and NGOs. By volunteering in either community initiatives or NGOs, participants learned composting and recycling. Velva participated in a food waste composting pilot program in her local town, and reading printed materials distributed by her local township is the major information source through which she has learned about composting and recycling. The printed flyer (see [Plate 2](#)) informs residents what types of food can or cannot be put into the compost bins. Velva described the wide variety of food waste that can be composted:

they [the composting pilot program] take everything from meats and cheeses and dairy and all, like the little ends of peppers, and things, um, that that you can't eat, you know, all the edibles of the fruits and vegetables, and, and even, and more like bread and rice and beans and all that and I can put that in there, shells bones. Velva

Reading a printed calendar (see [Plate 3](#)) also informed Velva when different materials will be collected or recycled in her town: "that will tell me again like what's recyclable, what's not, and also It shows me and my dates of my recycling, it gives me a calendar of when everything is, so I always keep the calendar up." Interestingly, after weighing wastes by a hanging scale, Velva was surprised to realize that her cat was the major source of waste in her household: "because with the pilot program we did a lot of weighting and the bulk of the waste that we had coming out of this house came from our cat." Reducing cat waste became a big challenge for Velva.

Similarly, Sharon learned about composting while volunteering in NGOs due to her altruism. She actively sought and volunteered in a local anti-GMO organization, aiming to



Source(s): Authors’ have been given permission by the participant to use this photo

Plate 2. Flyer of composting guide from local township

THURSDAY

Bottles & Cans • Newsprint • Corrugated • Mixed Papers

Jan	13	27	Jul	14	28	
Feb	9	24	Aug	11	25	
Mar	10	24	Sep	8	22	
Apr	7	21	Oct	6	20	
May	5	19	Nov	3	17	
Jun	2	16	Dec	1	15	29

Non-Thursday collection are circled

WEDNESDAY

Appliances • Tires • Metals • Automobile Batteries

Jan	12	Jul	13	27
Feb	2	Aug	10	24
Mar	2	Sep	14	28
Apr	20	Oct	19	
May	4	Nov	2	30
Jun	8	Dec	14	

THURSDAY

Vegetative Waste

Apr	13	21	28	Aug	4	11	18	25		
May	5	12	19	26	Sep	1	8	15	22	29
Jun	2	9	16	23	30	Oct	6	13		
Jul	7	14	21	28						

Non-Thursday collection are circled

Source(s): Authors’ have been given permission by the participant to use this photo

Plate 3. Recycling Calendar from local township

raise people’s awareness of food derived from genetically modified organisms (GMOs) and to propose new legislation requiring that GMO food be labeled. Although Sharon did not succeed in her efforts at worm composting, she acknowledged that much of her learning about composting came from this NGO and its social networks: “[I learned about composting from the non-profit organization] GMO Free, also some of the people there I’ve learned [. . .] more about it [composting] from them.”

NGOs thus also became information sources for participants, helping them solve problems and guiding everyday food choices. Both Sharon and Velva engaged with another NGO, the Environmental Working Group (EWG). EWG provides information on whether

or not produce is safe to eat after testing the number of pesticides and chemicals each year. Receiving and reading this food guide help them make daily food choices. Velva also described using the group's mobile application to seek information on clean cosmetics: "I do I use them [EWG] for sourcing things like cosmetics, and those kinds of products. They have great Apps."

Other participants who did not volunteer did also actively seek information from NGOs in order to expand and construct their information landscape. Samantha, who has an interest in organic gardening, described how she used the official website of Organic Farming Association to seek out local organic farmers and purchase local produce: "I did some research on the organic farming association of [state name], and through that, I found a guy [farmer] that does like gooseberries, elderberry, jostaberries." She used a similar strategy to find a healthcare provider specializing in functional medicine to give her advice on food choices:

I also found a doctor that's into functional medicine doctor. He's part of IFM Institute [The Institute for Functional Medicine], so he's been really helpful, as well as [telling me] different things I could do food-wise. Samantha

By engaging with NGOs, participants learned different ways to do sustainable food practices and sourced new information from official, credible websites. Therefore, for participants, NGOs served not only as places to share information but also as platforms from which to seek new information and new information sources.

4.3.2.2 Joining social media groups and following information creators. To gain more knowledge about their hobbies and topics of interest, participants searched for and joined special interest groups on social media. Samantha's gardening hobby led her to seek out and join greenhouse and gardening groups on Facebook, and her progress in gardening led her to join more groups:

I joined a couple [Facebook] groups. So once I built the greenhouse, I joined a hobby greenhouse group, and through that, you know, people post a lot of different things . . . then I joined a [state name] gardening group just this past weekend Samantha

After joining these groups, Samantha noted that people often post gardening issues or problems to learn from the expertise of others in the groups: "when you have issues, like, it's okay to post pictures about it. It's okay to post you're not successful things because that's how you learn."

Ann, a beach lover, was interested in sea surfing and joined many surf rider organizations, some of them educated surf riders to protect beach environments. Gradually, she joined other related groups about sustainability on Facebook: "I am now involved in a lot of Facebook groups. [. . .] zero waste groups and sustainability groups." Participants described gleaning a variety of types of information on social media. For example, Linda said, "there's tons of stuff on Instagram that I'll see that tells you about the impact of plastic and how long it lasts."

Besides joining social media groups, some participants followed particular content or information creators, sourced from the current information resources and social networks or searched online, who shared their interests. Alma, for example, took a local in-person gardening course for a local botanical garden, and that led her to follow one teacher's gardening broadcast to learn more about gardening:

I was a child gardener at the [local garden] . . . he also taught the fundamentals of gardening course at the [local] botanical garden . . . and that is how it really started, listening to [name of the broadcaster] on the garden hotline on a Sunday morning when my babies were little. Alma

Just as Alma learned more about home gardening after listening to and following this broadcaster, other participants learned from content creators how to make their own food and reduce food wastes. Ann described her learning experience after following an Instagram account:

I follow an account on Instagram. . . . and they started sharing lots of recipes with people, and they started selling their products and. so I follow[ed] them, and they posted about making fire cider leading into the winter, and, you know, wanting to kick up immunity, so that's where I learned about fire cider and I followed their recipe, and then they also are very big on reducing food waste, and so they said, you can dehydrate it. Ann

From Instagram, Ann learned different recipes for sustainable meals and techniques to reduce food waste. She excitedly shared how she made turkey stock and stored it in reused glass jars by following recipes from social media (see [Plate 4](#)): “I like reuse a lot of jars too. And then on the top I put a piece of tape. I use masking tape, and I write what it is and the date that I made it, so this was Turkey stock that I made in January of 22”.

Participants described both passive encounters with information from social media accounts they followed and actively searches for more information sources or content creators, beginning from their existing information sources and snowballing out from there. Samantha, for instance, was able to chain and follow more information creators after listening to the podcast from a current podcaster in food-related topics:

And then via [name of the podcaster], I found out a lot of different food people from his podcast so, then I would listen to those podcasts, and then I found [name of another podcaster]. I listened to him for quite a while; he has someone named [name] on his podcast. So I'm really into her. She has a blog as well. She's very into the clean eating, so I listened to her [podcast]. Samantha

Samantha's information snowballing techniques—also known as “chaining”—led her to find more relevant information creators. This type of chaining ([Ellis, 1989](#)) or footnote chaining ([Bates, 1989](#)) are common search strategies researchers or students use to find relevant research articles from reference lists or footnotes; participants in this study demonstrate that chaining is also used in leisure and everyday life contexts when participants are especially interested in certain topics.

4.3.2.3 Seeking and consuming media. Participants also reported seeking out and watching documentaries about nutrition and sustainable food practices for many reasons: simple curiosity or concerns over personal health, climate change or animal welfare. One participant, Emily, has been vegan for more than six years and perceives eating animals as immoral. She searched for and watched many documentaries about vegan diets on the Internet, learning about the benefits of veganism and the unethical aspects of consuming animal products:

I Googled like, you know, biggest vegan documentaries, and there's some really like common ones, like Seaspiracy and like Forks Over Knives. There's one that's newer called like, The Game Changers,



Source(s): Authors' have been given permission by the participant to use this photo

Plate 4. Homemade turkey stocks by following recipe posted on social media

and they're all focused on a different facet of veganism like ethic, reality, environment, nutritional value. Emily

Similarly, Linda, and Ann both reported searching documentaries on Google, though they could not recall the titles:

Those ones [documentaries] that show you all damage that that [factory] farming has caused, and plowing land that is caused like in the Amazon rainforest. I won't remember it by name. Linda

In addition to learning about animal welfare and factory farming, participants reported learning about social and climate issues in the palm industry, plastic packaging, and fast fashion in their documentary watching. Ann described her experience with documentaries about plastic:

The Story of Plastic was a good documentary there's a, there's one on balloons. I think it's what is it like the rubber jellyfish or something like that, um. there's just there's so many of them I can't remember all of them right now, so we just started, I started caring about it [plastic issues] Ann

In summary, participants constructed their information landscapes by actively engaging in sustainable food practices and by seeking out and following information sources. Those information activities include volunteering in NGOs, sourcing information from information sources, joining social media groups, watching documentaries, and following and chaining information creators.

4.3.3 Snowballing information. When participants construct their information landscapes by actively seeking out information sources and engaging in sustainable food practices, they shared their interests, leisure, hobbies or altruism with their information sources, which leads to the acquisition of new information and information sources. For instance, participants reported shared interests with others by talking to friends and family members; meeting with members from NGOs; joining, posting or commenting in social media groups; clicking advertisements; searching for topics of interest; and reading news, reports, or books on multiple different places (e.g. grocery stores, botanical gardens, local farms) and information systems (e.g. social media platforms, news media, search engines). After participants expressed their interests or information needs socially and algorithmically, information sources proactively provided relevant information and/or sources, leading participants to both new information and new sources of information—the process I call information snowballing. Over time, as participants shared or expressed their interests, leisure, hobbies or altruism with their information sources, participants became less likely to encounter information by accident and more likely to encounter it through snowballing; in other words, information began to snowball in from different information sources.

4.3.3.1 Snowballing from NGOs. Participants actively engaged in NGOs, where they encountered and acquired relevant information and new information sources. By volunteering with a local non-GMO organization, Sharon gained access to workshops and webinars mentioned in the organization's email advertisements: "because just from doing them in the past they send you ads for upcoming webinars, so I choose ones that I like." In-person social events organized by NGOs also give members the opportunity to encounter information. Alma described how she learned about the native plant movement and connected with individuals with similar interests at a social event organized by the local botanical garden: "so going there and meeting the people who are involved. . . . so by networking and connecting and asking questions."

NGOs also served as information creators. For instance, Sharon and Velva both received an annual report from [EWG.org](https://www.ewg.org) each year to guide food shopping (see [Plate 5](#)). Velva described how she encounters information from EWG.org: "they [EWG] also send out, there's a lot of information about which are the dirty dozen, and which are the clean foods like they send that out every year for shopping. [It] is like a good guide on what products are."

4.3.3.2 Snowballing from media. Like NGOs, social and digital media gave participants access to encounters with new information or new information sources: content creators, recommendations from algorithms, and posts or shares by other members in shared interest groups helped flesh out participants' information landscape.

Both Linda and Ann followed several sustainability-related accounts on Instagram, a social media platform that allows users to post images and videos. Ann described learning about recipes and tips for reducing food waste via one particular social media account on Instagram: "They're just a couple who started kind of doing what I do, and it grew and grew and grew, and then they had this like a mega garden, and they started sharing lots of recipes with people, and they started selling their products . . . they also are very big on reducing food waste."

Other participants encountered information recommended by social media algorithms. This is how Linda learned about the environmental threat of plastics: "This stuff probably just comes up in my algorithm . . . yeah, there's tons of stuff on Instagram that I'll see that tells you about the impact of plastic and how long it lasts." Emily described learning about veganism by watching videos recommended by the YouTube algorithm, based on her viewing history: "somehow somewhere based off the YouTube videos I was watching, it targeted me to watch like what are you eat today as it was in person."

Still others described encountering information via special interest groups (SIGs) on social media, where members shared and created information. Samantha describes joining a gardening group and connecting with people with similar interests: "I saw this guy had really cool micro tomatoes, so I started corresponding with him. . . . He's actually from [another country]. He just shipped them out to me today. [I'm] really excited. These micro tomato plants, and I'm going to be sharing some seeds that I have with him." Here, information that snowballed from a SIG led to Samantha acquiring new information about gardening as well as sharing seeds.

Ann described how her engagements in SIGs opened the door for information about her interests to find her: "And I think just over time, I started coming across that information. Being a part of all the groups that I'm in and all the interests that I have like that, information just comes up for me."

Finally, participants reported encountering information by reading news media and reports. Louise described how she learned the benefits of purchasing fruits and veggies in season or the number of recycled materials that went to the landfill by reading news articles online: "from reading about it from having an interest in reading articles around sustainability online, in print . . . I think I might have read it in the New York Times or at the BBC website and NPR."

4.3.3.3 Snowballing from individuals with similar interests. Participants also encountered new information and sustainability practices from other individuals with similar interests. April described learning about the farm-to-table program from environmentally conscious friends who owned restaurants: "So, I actually have a lot of [environmental] friends who



Source(s): The official website of the Environmental Working Group (<https://www.ewg.org>)

Plate 5. Receiving food guides by signing up by email on NGOs' website

own those restaurants that bring in the food from the local market [or] from the local farms. . . . I've known about it for a while." Although April did not have a specific source for or formal education in these topics, related information just appeared to her because of her vegetarianism: "Over time, you just hear, you hear things for you." And Linda, who shared interests with her husband's family in vegan diet and sustainability, described watching documentaries shared by them: "Sometimes they give us recommendations [on documentaries about the environment]. They're into sustainability as well."

Participants also reported that knowing people with similar interests helped them to reduce the overwhelm of information that could result from social and algorithmic approaches to information seeking. When Samantha realized that she was experiencing information overload from using TikTok, she decided to only engage with information selected and shared by a friend: "I don't have my own TikTok. I'm not trying to get into that rabbit hole . . . but anything my friend shares with me that garden related that I will click on and watch." Samantha's friends thus served as information gatekeepers to help her filter relevant information that fits her interests.

4.3.3.4 Snowballing through everyday food practices. Participants interested in sustainability also encountered information in everyday grocery shopping. Food packaging was an important information source for knowledge acquisition. For example, April discovered the issue of the sustainability of different oils used in the food industry by reading marketing information on food packaging (see [Plate 6](#)). She described her experience:

I think it's really interesting how companies are using their products to help share information. Like, I bought potato chips, and on the back, it says that you know they are using their corn oil . . . they talk about how it [using corn oil] is more sustainable than, obviously, using the diesel oils.

Ann learned about CSA while purchasing food from a local farmer: "when I was purchasing them the person who was at the market, she told me about it [CSA program]." Everyday shopping often includes non-food purchases, such as health and beauty products (e.g. shampoo, cleansers), or food-related products (e.g. composting bins), and some participants described learning about sustainability while shopping for these other types of products. Louise described learning more about composting food wastes after purchasing a compost bin: "the compost bins come with a user manual, you know, what you can compose, what you can't compost." For these participants, information was snowballed through grocery shopping, talking to food providers and buying products.

5. Discussion

Information snowballing consists of three stages: (1) information exposure and encountering, (2) constructing an information landscape and (3) snowballing information. Those three stages do not always start from stage 1 or happen in a specific sequence; each participant's trajectory varied, because participants can develop a new interest or hobby or express existing interests at any time (see [Figure 1](#)). For Ann, her hobby of surfing led her to join surf rider organizations (stage 2: constructing information landscape), where people within those organizations shared information about the negative impact of plastics on the ocean (stage 3: information snowballing).

Snowball sampling is a technique widely adopted by qualitative researchers in which new, relevant participants are recruited from participants' social networks ([Noy, 2008](#); [Parker et al., 2019](#)). This study found that a similar snowballing technique—*information snowballing*— is used by laypeople to acquire new and relevant information and/or information sources. As the data demonstrates, participants gradually acquired, or *snowballed*, new information and information sources pertaining to certain topics of interest (e.g. sustainability, sustainable food practices) from information sources in their constructed information landscapes, such as NGOs, backyards, social media groups, information creators followed on social media, and friends or family members. Like



Source(s): Kettle Brand Store at Amazon (<https://a.co/d/12Gq8FJ>)

Plate 6. Snowballing or acquiring sustainability-related information from food packaging

snowball sampling, information snowballing emphasizes the snowball effect of ever-increasing accumulation—here, the accumulation of information based on one’s interests, hobbies or altruism. The proposed concept reinforces people’s agency in information practices, as well as offers important insights into the information practices of learning and knowledge acquisition in everyday information practices.

IE research has predominantly focused on the “accidental” or “unexpected” discovery of relevant or useful information when participants either actively seeking or not seeking information (e.g. [Bernier, 1960](#); [Erdelez, 1995](#)). However, information snowballing indicates that information encountered by participants with specific interests, hobbies or altruism is not just serendipitous but intentional. When participants have an interest or hobby or demonstrate altruism, they snowballed information because they had been deliberately seeking relevant information or information sources. For instance, participants described joining special interest groups on social media, volunteering in NGOs, browsing interested news media, or chatting with friends and families about their interests. The agentic information practices were also observed in health information practices, such as young parents triangulating and making sense of health-related information for decision-making in everyday life ([Greyson, 2018](#)) or vaccine-hesitant adults engaging in agentic information literacy practices in the COVID-19 context ([Hicks and Lloyd, 2022](#)). Therefore, this study offers an example of how people exercise agency—one’s power and capacity to act intentionally—in everyday food choices, a concept often limited and overlooked in information practices research and everyday food practices.

In its identification of the early stage of information snowballing, learning by lifelong exposure and encountering, this study reveals the lifelong process in IE, extends pre-encountering tasks ([Erdelez and Makri, 2020](#)) to everyday food contexts and provides empirical evidence for such everyday information encounters, such as encountering information while accessing gardens as a child, working in a healthy grocery store as a

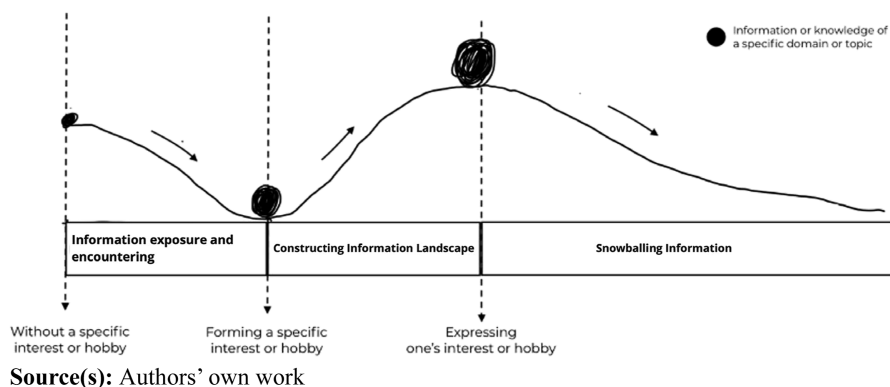


Figure 1. Information snowballing

teen, and leisure reading as an adult. More importantly, the everyday food-related tasks that facilitated IE were closely related to *place*—a concept that has become fundamental to the study of information access and information marginalization (Gibson and Kaplan, 2017), but has yet to be paid much attention in information behaviors and practices research. Findings from this study suggest that *places* in everyday food contexts are crucially important for information access, exposure, encountering and snowballing. However, place brings with it social and cultural factors that can not only facilitate but also hinder participants' IE. For instance, participants acknowledged their privilege in being able to access places like botanical gardens or healthy grocery stores; Alma noted that “I was very fortunate to have ready access to the [a borough name] botanic garden,” and Linda described her information exposure as a “unique case” due to her work experience in a local healthy grocery store like Whole Foods, while Louise noted the cultural and historical background for her information exposure, saying “there was much more of a culture of reusing or being resourceful.” Therefore, contextual factors (e.g. privilege to access places, public policy, family heritage) may also be integrated into our understanding of IE and place in information behaviors and practices research.

The concept of information snowballing also reveals the interplay between information *acquiring* and information *expressing*, two essential concepts in the Extended Everyday Information Practices (E-EIP) model (Savolainen and Thomson, 2022) (based on the Everyday Information Practices model developed by Savolainen (2008)). *Acquiring* refers to information seeking and use, and *expressing* represents not only the use and sharing of existing information but also the creation of information. People move back and forth between information *acquiring* and *expressing*: “once past a certain point of establishment or acquaintance, the balance of an individual's actions may switch to expressing the same combination of skills, knowledge, and experience, in embodied ways, written ways, spoken ways, and more” (Savolainen and Thomson, 2022, p. 9).

Findings from this study not only provide empirical evidence to support this interrelationship but also indicate that there is a blurry boundary between information *acquiring* and *expressing* for laypeople in everyday practices. For instance, participants in this study acquired knowledge and information by following content creators (e.g. YouTubers, podcasters); by subscribing to NGOs' newsletters; by browsing posts and advertisements on social media; or by chatting with friends and families and networking in social events or places. Although participants were acquiring information, they, at the same time, were expressing or sharing their interests with content creators, algorithms, NGOs, friends and family members, etc. Meanwhile, the above-mentioned information sources will record, recommend, share or even create relevant information based on their interests. Participants thus expressed their interests while searching for and acquiring information by asking

questions. Additionally, this study adds new evidence of embodied ways of *expressing*, such as participants could teach their kids how to harvest, compost, garden or raise chickens in backyards. As a result, information snowballing contributes to our understanding of laypeople's information acquiring and expressing and challenges the boundary between information acquiring and expressing in everyday information practices.

Further, the interplay between acquiring and expressing leads to the construction and maintenance of the information landscape. In the E-EIP model, information *expressing* has been limited to published information, created by experts or YouTubers (Savolainen and Thomson, 2022; Thomson, 2018). However, this study reveals a new concept of information expressing and acquiring through snowballing. After expressing interests or hobbies, individual food practitioners may snowball relevant information from information sources in their constructed information landscapes. Information landscapes are constructed through interactions between people who share similar goals, endeavors and situations (Lloyd, 2015, p. 8). This construction process is linked to different information sources, virtual and physical places, and information activities: as this study's findings suggest, information landscapes can be constructed through physically engaging in sustainable food practices (such as volunteering in NGOs, composting and recycling in local communities and gardening) or by engaging with digital information acquisition (browsing social media, consuming media, and searching online about sustainability based on hobbies, interests or altruism). Thus, information snowballing bridges two formerly disconnected concepts in LIS: the E-EIP model and the Information Landscape as contexts in everyday information practices.

Information snowballing also has practical implications for the field of food pedagogy, which highlights the importance of understanding "how the consumer goes about knowing food" (Goodman and DuPuis, 2002; see also Swan and Flowers, 2015). Food pedagogy is not limited to formal education but also comprises informal and adult education (Flowers and Swan, 2012; Lewis and O'Neil, 2019), and by revealing the information and knowledge acquisition processes of individual food practitioners, this study suggests different approaches to informing and educating adults about food and sustainability. For instance, information or knowledge can be shared with individual food practitioners through objects (e.g. food packaging), places (e.g. grocery stores, local farms, botanical gardens and backyards), social groups (e.g. groups for hobbyists in gardening, cooking, hiking and surfing), entertainment media (e.g. documentaries), organizations (e.g. healthy eating, non-GMO NGOs), or through embodied modeling (e.g. teaching composting, recycling or gardening). Through these different modalities, information about sustainability could be incorporated into different information landscapes, facilitating IE and exposure and raising public awareness about issues of sustainability. Further, although information snowballing explains the information practices of sustainable or ethical food consumers, it may also apply to information practices of other population groups in everyday life contexts, such as when they volunteer their time to acquire information, skills and knowledge based on their interests, hobbies or altruism. Future research should test the transferability of information snowballing to other domains.

Only a few participants reported experiencing information overload or avoidance during information snowballing. Although this study cannot fully explain information avoidance during and after information snowballing, it suggests important directions for future research, such as how participants interact with information when they have gained enough or more than enough information. Another possible area for future research is the interplay between information snowballing and misinformation. It could be argued that snowballing can create filter bubbles, where misinformation may propagate (MacFarlane *et al.*, 2022). The relationship between information snowballing and filter bubbles should be studied in future research. The present study does have some other limitations. First, it has a small sample size. Second, since participants were mainly recruited via social media, most were likely to be active social media users, and social media groups or social networks may play a more important role in their everyday lives than they do in the lives of people recruited in other ways. Future research could recruit participants from physical places like local grocery stores or farmers' markets in order to

reach more *nontypical* ethical consumers, like those who buy local produce to benefit neighbors (Schoolman, 2020). Third, although this study explores how people volunteer their time to acquire skills and knowledge about sustainable food practices, it did not use Serious Leisure (SL) framework to guide participants recruitment. Future research could employ the SL framework to recruit or classify participants in the SL domain (see Joseph, 2016; Stebbins, 2007). One further limitation is the time of year when participants are recruited, for this affects the data collected: for example, gardeners may mainly rely on grocery shopping during the winter but obtain most of their produce from their own gardens in the summer. This study recruited mainly during the winter time and that may have affected the results. Future research should pay attention to seasonal variation when collecting data. Finally, future research may wish to broaden this study's methodology to attend to areas of ethical consumption outside of food practices; another information-rich area might be sustainable fashion, for a few participants mentioned their difficulty of transitioning toward sustainable fashion practices or finding information about corporate's sustainable practices in fashion industry.

6. Conclusion

This study explored the information practices of individual sustainable food practitioners, especially the ways that they acquire information and get informed about sustainability-related issues. The findings reveal a process of *information snowballing* that includes several stages: exposure to and encountering of information due to external factors, even without a preexisting particular interest in a topic; gradually developing an interest and then actively constructing information landscapes based on that interest or altruism; and slowly and passively snowballing information shared by information sources within that information landscape. These findings contribute to the theoretical development of information and knowledge acquisition in the context of everyday food in information science; it highlights the agentic information practices in sustainable food practices; it connects concepts from everyday information practices to information landscapes; and it has empirical implications for raising public awareness of sustainability through informal education.

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